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national platform. "Music is very big in the North-east, though not necessarily Hindi film songs," says Debbarma, who did not receive any formal training in music. Today, as she croons flawlessly in Hindi ignoring remarks like *chinky* and "flat face" on her album trailers on YouTube, one can't help recalling how she was criticised in the show for her diction.

People from the region have long opposed the move by mainstream India to club the seven states and Sikkim under one label—the North-east. "We have very little in common except that the rest of India thinks we look the same," says theatre director Ratan Thiyam. But today, entertainment seems to have united them. Debbarma's votes came not just from Tripura but from the other seven states. So was the case with Bhutia, Saha and Paul.



SOURABHEE DEBBARMA 23

PROFESSION Singer

PROVENANCE Tripura

CLAIM TO FAME In 2009, she became the first girl to win *Indian Idol*, a musical reality show on Sony TV

CURRENT STATUS Is working on a Rs 1-crore contract that she bagged from Sony TV. Will release her first music album *Meherbaan* soon.



SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN

JULIE KAGTI 38

PROFESSION Textile and fashion designer

PROVENANCE Assam

CLAIM TO FAME One of the first designers from the North-east to participate in the Lakme India Fashion Week

CURRENT STATUS Is establishing her eponymous label; has just opened her new prêt studio in Bangalore

Garg who has sung more than 10,000 songs in various languages. Another Assamese, Reema Kagti, 35, was rejected thrice by the Film and Television Institute of India, Pune, before her persistence saw her learn the craft with some of the best directors in the industry, including Rajat Kapoor and Farhan Akhtar. In 2007, she made her debut as a director with *Honeymoon Travels Pvt. Ltd.*, which went on to become a multiplex hit. "I was 15 when I saw *Salaam Bombay* and since then wanted to become a filmmaker, though it was unheard of in a middle-class Assamese family," says Kagti.

Rewind to the 1970s and we had Asha Parekh in a kimono playing a Japanese girl and Mumtaz cleverly made up with slightly slanting eyes playing Dev Anand's Nepali sweetheart in *Hare Rama Hare Krishna*. Not anymore it seems, thanks to the surge of models from the North-east. While super model Monikangana Dutta, 26, from Assam has made it to international league, other successful models like Shruti Agarwal, 24, and Geetanjali Thapa, 21—both from Sikkim—are trying their luck in Bollywood. Thapa will probably be the first solo heroine in Bollywood from the North-east. "I'm happy the role required me to look the way I do," says Thapa who was planning to pur-